

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 50

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: A search-and-rescue dog handler is called out at dusk to look for a child who has wandered from a nearby campsite.

1

The call came at twenty past seven, just as the kettle began to whistle. A boy of six, missing from a campsite at the lower edge of the pine wood, last seen ninety minutes ago near the wash-block. I wrote the details on the pad by the telephone in the careful, blocky letters I always use when I am trying not to hurry. Bella, who had been asleep on the kitchen tiles, lifted her head before I had even put the receiver down. She had read the change in my voice the way she always did, several seconds before I knew it was there.

2

I dressed methodically. There is no advantage, on a job like this, in rushing the boots or forgetting the head torch. Waterproof trousers. A spare fleece, sealed in a dry bag, for the child rather than for me. Whistle, GPS, radio, water, a foil blanket, two energy bars, a small first-aid kit. Bella stood beside the kit bag with her harness across her shoulders like a working coat, watching each item disappear into the rucksack. When I clipped on her bell, she shook herself once — a small, businesslike shudder — and walked to the door.

3

The campsite warden met me at the gate. A pale, thin woman in a fleece two sizes too large, twisting her radio cord around her fingers. The parents, she said, were “trying very hard not to cry”, which I understood to mean that they were crying. I asked for an item of the boy’s clothing. She produced a small blue t-shirt from a sealed plastic bag, and I held it out for Bella to take a long, considering sniff. Bella’s nose worked carefully along the cotton, learning it. Then she looked up at me with the steady, slightly impatient expression I have come to trust more than any briefing.

4

We entered the wood at the corner where the boy had last been seen. The light, by then, was the soft,

used-up grey of a summer evening on the point of giving in. Beneath the pines it was already darker. I kept Bella on a long line for the first hundred metres, partly because the ground was uneven and partly because I wanted to read her before I trusted her. She moved with her nose held a little above the leaf litter, casting gently from side to side, the way she does when the scent is faint but clearly present. I have learnt, over the years, to wait for her to tell me what she has found. Handlers who try to guide their dogs in these moments tend to find nothing.

5

After perhaps ten minutes, Bella's whole body changed. Her tail lifted from its working curve to a higher, quicker beat. Her ears pricked forward, then flattened, then pricked again. She had the air of a dog who was very certain about something she had not yet bothered to share with me. I unclipped the long line. She moved away at a brisk, purposeful trot, not running, never running — a trained dog does not run, because a running dog frightens a frightened child — and I followed her up a slight rise, between two stands of young pines, into a clearing where a single old tree had fallen across the bracken.

6

He was sitting in the hollow beside the trunk. A small boy in a green jumper, knees pulled up to his chest, both hands wrapped around a stick as though it were a sword. He was not crying. He had, I could see at once, decided some time ago that crying would not help. Bella stopped two metres short of him, sat, and gave the single, soft “found” bark she has been taught — a bark that is more of a polite cough than an announcement. The boy looked up. He looked at the dog. Then he looked at me, very steadily, and said, “I knew somebody would come.”

7

I knelt down, slowly, at the same distance Bella had chosen. I asked his name. I asked whether anything hurt. I asked whether he would like to say hello to the dog who had found him. He nodded to all three questions in turn, in the grave, careful way of a child who has been frightened and has decided to be brave about it. The fleece from the dry bag went around his shoulders. The radio call went out — found, well, walking out. Bella, released from her formal posture, leaned her warm flank against the boy's side and accepted, with great dignity, the small hand that came up to rest on her head.

8

We walked the three of us back through the wood in a quiet that felt larger than the silence it had replaced. Behind us, the pines stood still in the last light. Ahead, beyond the treeline, I could already see the small, hurrying figures of two parents running, then trying not to run, then running again. Bella glanced up at me once, just once, in the way she does when a job has gone the way it should. I rested my hand briefly on the top of her head. There was, as there always is on these evenings, nothing very dramatic to say.

From Paragraph 1

1. The narrator says she wrote the details “in the careful, blocky letters I always use when I am trying not to hurry.” Explain, in your own words, what this tells us about how she approaches her work. [2]

2. What does the description of Bella in Paragraph 1 suggest about the relationship between the dog and the handler? [2]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator notes that she packs “a spare fleece, sealed in a dry bag, **for the child rather than for me.**” What does this small detail reveal about the nature of her work? [2]

From Paragraph 3

4. The warden says the parents are “trying very hard not to cry”, which the narrator understands “to mean that they were crying.” Explain the **effect** of the writer expressing the parents’ distress in this indirect way. [2]

5. The narrator describes Bella’s look as “steady, slightly impatient” and one she trusts “more than any briefing.”

(a) Why is the word **impatient** surprising here? [1]

(b) What does the comparison with “any briefing” tell us about the handler’s view of her dog? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. The narrator says, “Handlers who try to guide their dogs in these moments tend to find nothing.” Explain, in your own words, what this sentence shows about the **professional skill** of a good handler. [2]

From Paragraph 5

7. In Paragraph 5, the narrator gives several signs that Bella has detected something important. Give **two** such signs from the paragraph. [2]

8. Explain why the writer adds the comment that “a trained dog does not run, because a running dog frightens a frightened child.” [2]

From Paragraph 6

9. The boy is described as holding a stick “as though it were a sword”, and as having “decided some time ago that crying would not help.” What do these two details, taken together, suggest about the boy? [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says Bella “accepted, with great dignity, the small hand that came up to rest on her head.” Explain why the word **dignity** is effective in this sentence. [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article on the promise and peril of geoengineering — deliberate, large-scale intervention in the Earth's climate system.

1

For most of the last century, the idea of deliberately altering the Earth's climate belonged to science fiction. Today, it sits — uncomfortably, urgently — on the agenda of serious research institutions, national academies, and a growing number of climate panels. The reason is plain. Emissions of carbon dioxide are still rising; the warming targets set out in the Paris Agreement are slipping out of reach; and the gap between what governments have promised and what they have actually delivered grows wider every year. Against that backdrop, the question of whether humans should consider intervening directly in the climate system — geoengineering, for short — can no longer be politely ignored.

2

Geoengineering is usually divided into two large families. The first, **solar-radiation management**, aims to cool the planet by reflecting a little more sunlight back into space. Proposals include injecting fine sulphate particles into the upper atmosphere, brightening marine clouds with sea-salt spray, or even — at the most speculative end — placing reflective objects in orbit. The second family, **carbon-dioxide removal**, aims at the underlying cause of the problem by drawing the gas back out of the atmosphere. Methods range from the prosaic, such as planting forests and restoring peatlands, to the technological, such as direct-air-capture machines and the storage of captured carbon deep underground.

3

The case for taking these ideas seriously is not, on the face of it, an unreasonable one. The Intergovernmental Panel on Climate Change has concluded that some form of carbon-dioxide removal is now almost certainly necessary if the world is to keep warming below 1.5°C. Solar-radiation management, in particular, offers something no other tool can: it could, in principle, lower temperatures within months rather than decades, providing a kind of emergency brake while slower measures take effect. Several scientists have argued that to refuse even to study these options would be irresponsible — a refusal to know what is possible at a moment when knowing has rarely mattered more.

4

The case against, however, is at least as strong, and in many ways more troubling. The first concern is **unintended consequences**. The climate is a coupled, non-linear system whose behaviour is famously difficult to predict; an intervention designed to cool one region might disrupt monsoons in another, with severe consequences for the food supplies of billions. The second is **moral hazard**. If governments come to believe that a technological fix is on the horizon, they may feel less urgency about the unglamorous, expensive work of cutting emissions today. The third, perhaps the most serious of all, is **governance**. There is, at present, no international body with clear authority to decide who may deploy these techniques, under what conditions, and on whose behalf. A single wealthy nation, or even a single wealthy individual, could in theory begin altering the planet's climate without the consent of anyone else who lives on it.

5

Despite these concerns, small experiments are already underway. A trial in Iceland is removing carbon dioxide from the air and turning it into stone within underground basalt. A project off the coast of Australia has been spraying fine seawater mist over the Great Barrier Reef to test whether brightened clouds can reduce coral bleaching. In the United States, a Harvard-led proposal to release a few kilograms of calcium-carbonate dust from a high-altitude balloon — purely to study atmospheric mixing — was halted in 2021 after local communities raised objections it had failed to consult them about. The pattern is

revealing: even the smallest experiments now arrive into a political environment that is, rightly, unwilling to grant the scientific community a free hand.

6

What, then, should an informed citizen watch for? Three things, at least. First, the language. When a politician begins to speak of geoengineering as a substitute for emissions cuts rather than a complement to them, that is a warning sign. Second, the governance arrangements. Any deployment that proceeds without genuine international agreement — particularly agreement that includes the countries most exposed to climate harm — is unlikely to be either fair or stable. Third, the funding. A field dominated by a small number of private donors, with little public oversight, will tend, in the long run, to serve the priorities of those donors rather than those of the broader public.

7

None of this is an argument against research. It is an argument for taking geoengineering seriously enough to think about it carefully, and humbly enough to admit how much we still do not know. The temptation, when a problem feels overwhelming, is to reach for the most dramatic remedy on the shelf. The temptation, when a remedy looks dramatic, is to assume it must therefore be effective. Both temptations should be resisted. The cheapest tonne of carbon dioxide, as the engineers say, is the one we never emit in the first place — and no machine, no aerosol, no orbiting mirror has yet shown that it can change that simple fact.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that the idea of altering the climate now sits “uncomfortably, urgently” on the research agenda. Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how scientists feel about geoengineering today. [2]

From Paragraph 2

13. In your own words, explain the **difference** between the two main families of geoengineering described in Paragraph 2. [2]

From Paragraph 3

14. According to Paragraph 3, give **two** reasons why some scientists believe geoengineering deserves serious study. [2]

15. The writer describes solar-radiation management as “a kind of emergency brake.” Explain why this comparison is effective. [2]

From Paragraph 4

16. Explain, in your own words, what is meant by **moral hazard** as described in Paragraph 4. [2]

17. The writer says, “A single wealthy nation, or even a single wealthy individual, could in theory begin altering the planet’s climate without the consent of anyone else who lives on it.” What is the **effect** of this sentence on the reader? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says the Harvard balloon proposal was halted after local communities “raised objections it had failed to consult them about.” What does this incident reveal about the relationship between scientific experiments and the public? [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. Why does the writer warn against politicians who treat geoengineering as “a substitute for emissions cuts rather than a complement to them”? [2]

20. The writer suggests that a field “dominated by a small number of private donors” is a problem. In your own words, explain why. [2]

From Paragraph 7

21. The writer ends the text by reminding the reader that “the cheapest tonne of carbon dioxide... is the one we never emit in the first place.” What is the writer’s **purpose** in ending the text this way? [2]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the main arguments in favour of taking geoengineering seriously**, and **the main concerns that have been raised against it**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 3 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Supporters argue that geoengineering deserves serious study because ...

— END OF PAPER —